

There was excitement in the air, tension around the Adam's apple. iPhone had already swept the touch-screen market with its brand-new OS, zippy UI and the Safari browser that could turn every website into a sex bomb. Microsoft got another jolt when Google decided to take up the Linux kernel and build a mobile OS on top. And then HTC launched the G1. Alas! Nobody seemed to be interested in paying \$699 for a phone that ran an open source OS and depended on freelance developers for the apps. Neither could HTC themselves justify the price.

It was through this dynamic time that HTC also launched its most popular touch-screen brand, one version after another. First there was HTC Touch, followed by the Touch Diamond, Touch Pro, Diamond HD and many

more. What made these phones popular was their proprietary TouchFlo user interface. When HTC's other Android-based phones, the G2 and Magic, also got a lukewarm response, it decided to fuse its award-winning combination with Android, and thus was born the HTC Sense.

HTC Sense

HTC Sense is a user experience that's based on the TouchFlo 3D user interface, developed by HTC for mobile devices running Google Android. The Sense 'experience' is not, as it has often been described, a UI as such. Sense is just a "...design experience, an architecture that is all about how people use the device, making their content personal to how they use the device." HTC Hero is the first phone that shipped with HTC Sense. With its distinct design and powerful capabilities fully integrated with Sense, Hero introduces a unique blend of form and function that takes Android to new heights. HTC Sense is focused on putting people at the centre, by making your phone work in a more simple and natural way.

The Hero

It was written that a great Hero would rise from the East. He would be clothed in the sun and his unique user-interface would redefine the user experience for countless fans of social networking, and His Majesty would reign over all Android phones forever. That Hero is here, and he's on Airtel.

The phone was launched in September 2009, in India. It is the first Android device to support Adobe Flash, is HTC's first phone that's available worldwide, and is the first Android phone to host HTC's proprietary software, the widgets, add-ons and TouchFlo 3D elements. Smartphone fans seem to agree that the company



Figure 2: The Rear Side

has finally delivered what has been missing in the world of Android, namely, a polished and attractive device (polished enough to go head-to-head with the iPhone) with an open source heart.

"What's in the box?"

We received the Hero in a white rectangular box that contained the following:

- The HTC Hero
- A 1350 mAh battery
- A 128 MB Micro SD memory card
- A data cable that can be transformed into a ninja charger (*ala* the Auto Bots and Decepticons).

Form factor

The very moment you lay your eyes on the phone, you know that it's a product of sheer evolution. While all the HTC Android phones are designed the same, the sleek curve (known as 'the chin') right at the bottom seems to be an ergonomic, inviting design. No other mobile manufacturing company offers such quirky contours.

Housed on the front is the earpiece, covered by a fine grill. Right next to it is the service LED (glows red when the phone is being charged or is connected to a PC, and green when the battery is fully charged) and ambient light sensor that handles the display's backlight. Hero is the first phone that has a fused curved casing, almost-invisible volume rocker, trackball, touch-screen and matte plastic all at the same time. The bevelled edges along the back makes the handset sit comfortably in the hand. The plastic material that covers it



Figure 1: HTC Sense—enhanced Android experience